eighteenth-century Indore queen Ahilyabai Holkar; Lucknow's Begum Hazrat Mahal, who fought the British in 1857; and Captain Lakshmi Sehgal, who led the Rani Jhansi women's regiment in Subhash Chandra Bose's Indian National Army during the Second World War.[96]

The Veerangana meetings also worked to convince women workers that campaigning would not be unsafe for them. 'Women cannot be taken seriously unless they themselves take themselves seriously. We are so very dependent on the patriarchy around us,' said Tikoo. 'Sushma Swaraj focused on this a lot in her speeches. We said it doesn't take too much for a booth-level karykarta to go out at night and leave her home to campaign, but then her parents and relatives immediately complain saying that it is unsafe and that politics is dirty. So how do I know that she's going to be safe for the campaign? This thought was vitally debated in the party.' The new focus on women also created 'deep division between a lot of party leaders'. This was important because a woman getting a ticket or a party position was not in itself sufficient. 'Preparing, managing and using the campaign to empower yourself is also a big deal,' Tikoo explained. The question of giving more tickets to women, especially in important seats held by the BJP, was widely debated in the party. Then Rajnath Singh and Nitin Gadkari came out and said that 'when there was a discrepancy on seats, why not err on the side of giving it to a woman'.[97] Interestingly, the 2009 Lok Sabha election, under Rajnath Singh's stewardship, was the first in which the BJP fielded more women candidates than any other party in any Lok Sabha election (see Table 17.1).

Strategy 3: Women Beneficiaries High in Modi's Developmental Policies: How Much of the Woman Talk Did His Government Walk?

We have seen how much Prime Minister Modi and the BJP focus on women in their discourse and party mobilisation as well as the resultant impact on voting patterns. Obviously, mere political rhetoric —without action to match—would not be enough to draw women